Manoj Jarange-Patil, known for his agitation seeking OBC quotas for Marathas, has lashed out at Munde, while OBC leader Laxman Hake, seen as close to the Mahayuti, is making a counter-claim that an OBC leader like Munde is being made a victim of political scapegoating. A senior NCP leader claims Dhas is being propped up by the BJP leadership to emerge as a Maratha leader in the Marathwada region and eat into Jarange-Patil's space. In the Lok Sabha and assembly polls, Jarange-Patil, who has amassed support among a section of Maratha youth after months of firebrand quota activism, had taken a position against the BJP. The case has become a big headache for Fadnavis who met the deceased Deshmukh's family on January 7 at his Mumbai residence and assured them justice.

The NCP, traditionally seen as a Maratha-dominated party, faces a dilemma. Munde, one of its key OBC faces, plays a crucial role in balancing caste equations within the party. The senior NCP leader says Dhas is being used to weaken the dominance in Beed of the Munde cousins—Dhananjay and Pankaja, daughter of late BJP veteran Gopinath Munde, who is still with the saffron party and holds the environment portfolio in the Mahayuti regime. "Fadnavis and Dhananjay have a good equation. In the Lok Sabha election, the BJP faced a major setback in Beed (where Pankaja lost to the NCP-SP's Bajrang Sonwane) due to the Maratha quota protests. If the BJP leadership sides with Munde, they will be accused of being anti-Maratha," says Abhay Deshpande, a political analyst.

Munde could not be contacted for comments despite attempts. But a close aide explains the legal tack to INDIA TODAY: "There are two different cases—murder and extortion. An attempt is being made to mix the two for political ends." And resignation? He says it's out of the question. ■

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